of Mehrab Khan, his host was no less prescient in his final warning. ‘You have brought an army into the country,’ he said. ‘But how do you propose to take it out again?’[33q]

From the blinding white salt marshes of Dadur, the shimmering heat haze of the desert flatlands slowly gave way to rolling foothills. These in turn scrolled up to the silvery outlines of dragons’-backs rising in the distance from a summer dust storm: the great mountains of southern Afghanistan. The country remained burned out and ash-coloured, and as arid as before, but the gradient became increasingly steep and tortuous until the gaping funnel of the Bolan Pass suddenly opened blackly in front of the troops.

For the first four of the pass’s seventy miles, the enfilade was so narrow that only a single camel could advance at a time. Now, as the feet of the cavalry clattered uneasily over the rockfalls blocking the dry riverbed, the errors of the commanders began to multiply the casualties: the stifling winter uniforms of the infantry were far too hot for a steep ascent in baking summer temperatures, and even if the vertical cliff walls initially shielded the sepoys from the direct rays of the sun, the rocks reflected the heat into their faces like an open tandoor. By day, the thermometers in the airless tents registered 119 degrees.

The roads, which had not been properly surveyed or improved by the military engineers, were almost impossible to move artillery along. At first eight horses had to be attached to each gun, as well as lines of sepoys with drag ropes. Then as it grew steeper and stonier, the guns had to be dismantled and carried through by hand: ‘each gun, each tumbril, wagon &c was to be separately *handed* down by manual labour,’ recorded Major William Hough. ‘The ascent was so steep that some did not like to ride up it. A few camels fell and stopped the rest behind . . . The baggage was attacked with considerable spirit [by the Baluchis] at the head of the Pass; 49 camel loads of grain were carried off . . . [The rearguard] found on the road the mutilated bodies of many camp followers.’[34]

At night, the air was filled with the bedlam moans of dying camels and camp followers. Many sepoys also collapsed, sucking at the thin, dry, hot air, calling for water, only to be told that there was none. In addition to everything else, ‘the stench of the dead camels rendered our lives intolerable’, wrote Seaton. ‘I cannot describe our sufferings from the heat,